

channel. Although you may not buy one of those from the secondhand market, it still goes to show that there's always something to be done with old hardware.

Looking at more typical uses such as connecting online, all the dealers we contacted agreed that it doesn't cost much to get a PC that can. A non-expensive, reasonably fast system such as a Pentium II or a Celeron with a colour monitor and a multimedia kit would be a great computer to connect online. Quite a few cybercafés do just that. Pawan Gola, of Softech Cyber Café, Mira Road (a Mumbai suburb), runs several such Celeron systems that have 64 MB RAM, along with a Pentium III PC as the main server. He hasn't had any major hardware related problems with them—his major headaches are ensuring that worms and viruses don't wreak havoc.

Accounting, data entry and DTP work are yet other applications where a secondhand computer can be used. Accounting, in fact, is one application that can be done with an old computer. Though surrounded by laptops and PDAs, Plug n Play Technologies' Rushabh Shah still runs his accounting work on a 386, using DOS-based accounting software. For many years now, several banks have continued using legacy PCs to tackle accounting work, using older accounting software. They have worked fine, though they don't have the frills and extra features that newer software offer.

Fact of the matter is there's an application for just about any old computer. Arvind, for instance, lent his colleague's son his old BBC Micro, who uses it to practice BASIC. Computer classes also invest in older systems, since 2-year old computers will easily run compilers for many languages. Linux scores right over there, with even older versions of Linux having built-in support for several programming languages. Arvind's PC XT holds a lot of sentimental value for him, since it was his main rig for the longest time. He did extensive assembly coding on it and found it an enjoyable experience. He currently runs his 386 as a router for his home network. It runs a stripped down Debian Linux distribution. His friend set up the router, but he's pretty confident that he could now manage doing it himself. As he jokes, "it's not rocket science."

World-wide too, people have done a variety of things with old computers. Jack-

The Truth about Hardware

Complete Secondhand Systems

Desktop

386 with Mono Monitor - Rs 1,000
486 with Mono Monitor - Rs 1,500
PI with Colour Monitor - Rs 4,500
PII (350) with Multimedia*- Rs 8,000
Celeron (500) with Multimedia - Rs 9,000
PIII (550) - Rs 12,000

Hard Disk:

4 GB - Rs 1,500
8 GB - Rs 1,800
20 GB - Rs 2,300

RAM:

16 MB EDO - Rs 225
32 MB SD - Rs 300
64 MB SD - Rs 575

LAN Card - Rs 100
Modem - Rs 350
CD-ROM - Rs 400
VGA Card (PCI) - Rs 250
VGA Card (AGP) - Rs 400

Laptop

PII - Rs 32,000
PIII - Rs 42,000

For Laptops

40 GB hard disk - Rs 7,300
64 MB Laptop Memory - Rs 1,800
External USB CD-RW - Rs 5,700
PCMCIA LAN card - Rs 1,500
Battery (OEM) - Rs 6,000
Battery (Original) - Rs 8,000
Replacement LCD - Rs 2,000

Note: The 386 and 486 will only run DOS or Windows 3.11. To run Windows 95, you should have a Pentium PC with 16 MB RAM. These are indicative prices and they vary depending on the rest of the parts and on the condition of the machine.

*Multimedia would include a CD-ROM drive, sound card and speakers

son 'Metalrock' Low, a student at the California State Polytechnic University, Pomona, and his friends use a variety of systems, from a 486 onwards, for a range of tasks—right from running Web servers and FTP servers to programming and listening



Jackson Low 'Metalrock'
California State Polytechnic
University, Pomona
Founder of the MusiIRC.com
IRC network

"I personally use my Unix 486 box as an IRC server and MP3 player"

to music. He currently runs custom-tuned IRC daemons on a 486 Unix box as well as an Athlon 1 GHz running FreeBSD. A friend of his runs a Web server hosting a site on a range of 25 MHz systems!

But look...

There will always be an inherent risk when buying secondhand. Asif Syed, director of Lemon Net—a company that provides computing as a service for a contracted period of time to home users—says that buying a secondhand PC is a

"criminal waste of money". He goes on to explain that unlike business-buyers who buy PCs for others to use, home-users buy their computers for personal use. This makes the user experience all-important. "A computer has multiple purposes. And its value comes from the benefit the consumer gets from those purposes. So, if the user experience is not as good, the benefit is less." Hence, by buying a secondhand PC, you're essentially "buying something already outdated, which has lost its inherent money value." In addition, you always need to upgrade software, and to do that you also have to upgrade hardware. Spending Rs 10,000 on a PC worth Rs 5,000 does not increase its value that much. The bottom line as he says, is that "you have to keep spending to keep using it well."

A valid point, yet Arvind Chandrasekhar's approach to secondhand PCs is quite a practical one: "Brand new PCs make sense for first time buyers. Once you know what you're doing, it's okay to buy secondhand." If you do have some prior experience with computers, then you probably have a fair idea of what you need a PC for.

Hence, if you do your homework and invest wisely, you could get hold of a used PC, and get your work done for less.

KAIZAD VAJIFDAR

kaizad_vajifdar@thinkdigit.com

SRINIVASAN RAMAKRISHNAN

srinivasan_ramakrishnan@thinkdigit.com